Unit 14. Titus 1:5-9 (Encounter)

Overview

This unit applies the lessons of Unit 4 to Titus 1:5-9. In doing so it provides the learners with the opportunity to look at a passage from elsewhere in the pastorals, both as an appetiser and as an important passage in itself that leads into the final unit of the module.

Outline

- Introduction: Understanding Titus
- Understanding the Pastoral Epistles
- Worksheet for the passage
- Worksheet for Step 1
- Worksheet for Steps 2 to 4
- Preaching Titus 1:5-9

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Recall and apply the four steps of Encountering a Bible Passage to a passage from Titus
2. Explain the message of Titus 1:5-9 to a group of pastors today
3. Apply Titus 1:5-9 and evaluate your own life and ministry

14.1 INTRODUCTION: UNDERSTANDING TITUS

Titus is the final letter of the Pastoral Epistles. We have dipped into it already, particularly when looking at the gospel and how to share it in Units 6 and 7.

You will remember from Units 2 and 3 that in order to understand a Bible passage we must ‘Keep in mind the original CONTEXT of the Bible book’.

We noted that, ‘Trying to understand a passage of a book without knowing the book itself is like trying to get to know a member of a family without knowing their wider family and where they live.’

Before we look at Titus 1:5-9 we will do an introductory study of it, guided by Unit 3. We have already completed that exercise for 1 and 2 Timothy. We will build on that by thinking through some of the similarities and differences between Titus and 1 Timothy, the book that was written before Titus.

If you have enough time together read Titus through as a whole, it is shorter than the other letters. If you have limited time just look at the verses that are mentioned below, and read through Titus later.

14.1.1 Establish the context of Titus

Read through the book and look for indicators of the context. (Who is addressing whom? Who else is involved? Where is it being written to and from? Why has it been written?)

Note specific verses where you see either a **similarity** to 1 Timothy (things that are nearly the same), or a **difference** to it. Describe those similarities and differences by looking at the two books and moving between them.

- What **similarities** does Titus have to 1 Timothy in terms of the context?

Titus 1:4

Titus 1:5-9

Titus 1:10-11

Titus 2:1

Titus 3:12

- What **differences** does Titus have to 1 Timothy in terms of the context?

Titus 1:4

Titus 1:5, 12

14.1.2 Discover the content of Titus

As we have looked at the **context** of 2 Timothy we have begun to note the **content**. Build on that now by looking more closely at the content, the themes of the book.

- What **similarities** does Titus have to 1 Timothy in terms of the content?

Titus 1:9; 2:15

Titus 1:5-9

Titus 2:10b; 3:1-2, 8, 14

- What **differences** does Titus have to 1 Timothy in terms of the content?

Titus 1:1-3

Titus 2:11-14 and 3:3-7

You will grow in your understanding of Titus as you look at the passage that follows and connect it to the rest of the book. We will turn to that passage in a moment and apply the 4 steps of Encountering a Bible Passage to it.

But before we do, and now that we have looked at the background to all three books, we will look briefly at understanding the Pastoral Epistles as a whole.

14.2 UNDERSTANDING THE PASTORAL EPISTLES

14.2.1 The relationship between the individual Pastoral Epistles

We have now looked at the background of all three Pastoral Epistles: 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy and Titus. This is a good moment to use the similarities and differences between the letters to illustrate the relationship between the books. 1 and 2 Timothy have naturally been grouped together in our Bibles, but it seems that they were written in the order below:

1 Timothy

- From Paul who is in Macedonia (1:3) and free to travel, leaving Timothy in Ephesus.
- False teachers have already emerged from within the church leadership, they have established themselves and have begun to destroy the church.
- Being a true teacher of the gospel means stopping the false teachers and appointing other true teachers: this is the essential task.
- This is urgent and important.
- 1 Tim is probably the first of the three letters to be written.

Titus

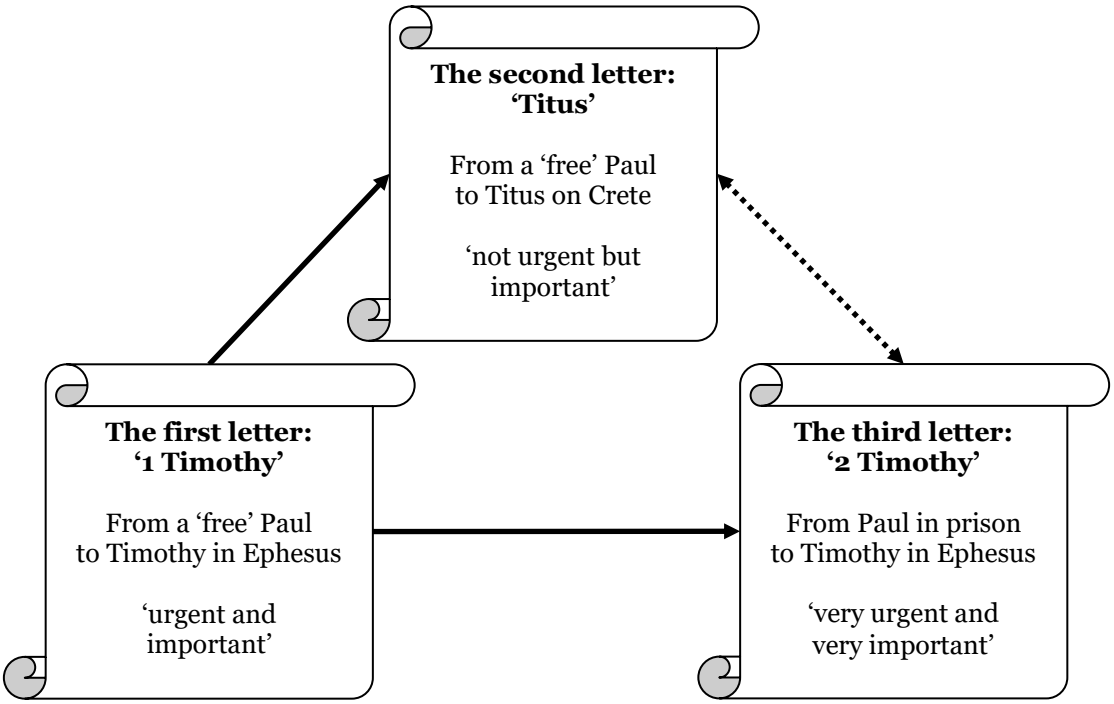
- From Paul who is still in Macedonia ("Nicopolis" on the coast, 3:12) and free to travel, leaving Titus on Crete.
- False teachers are already on the scene but the problems are less severe.
- Being a true teacher of the gospel and appointing other true teachers is still vital in order to protect the churches as they develop.
- This task is important but less urgent.
- Titus is probably the second of the three letters: it seems to be based on 1 Timothy but written for a different setting.

2 Timothy

- From Paul who is imprisoned in Rome and facing death, to Timothy in Ephesus.
- Being a true teacher of the gospel and passing gospel ministry on to other true teachers is now more important than ever. Partly so that Timothy can go to Paul's side, and partly so that true gospel ministry will continue and flourish.
- It is serious, extremely urgent, and highly important.

14.2.2 A way of illustrating the way the relationship between the three letters

The relationship between the three letters can be pictured in the way shown below.



The solid lines show direct connections: There is a direct connection between 1 Timothy and Titus: after writing 1 Timothy Paul may well have turned his attention to the less urgent, but still important, matters on Crete, using some of the same material.

And there is a direct connection between 1 Timothy and 2 Timothy: with Paul's imprisonment and a worsening situation in Ephesus he builds on 1 Timothy in 2 Timothy.

The dashed line shows an indirect link: There is only an indirect connection between 2 Timothy and Titus – they both relate to similar issues, and both arose out of 1 Timothy, but Paul is writing to different people in different places.

14.3 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING TITUS 1:5-9 – THE PASSAGE

5 The reason I left you in Crete was that
you might put in order what was left
unfinished and appoint elders in every
town, as I directed you. 6 An elder must be
blameless, faithful to his wife, a man
whose children believe and are not open
to the charge of being wild and
disobedient. 7 Since an overseer manages
God's household, he must be blameless –
not overbearing, not quick-tempered, not
given to drunkenness, not violent, not
pursuing dishonest gain. 8 Rather, he must
be hospitable, one who loves what is good,
who is self-controlled, upright, holy and
disciplined. 9 He must hold firmly to the
trustworthy message as it has been
taught, so that he can encourage others by
sound doctrine and refute those who
oppose it. (NIV)

14.4 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING TITUS 1:5-9 – STEP 1

STEP 1: FLESH – study the DETAILS of the text

a) Set the passage in context. How does the passage relate to the book as a whole?

b) See the details of the text. List important words, phrases, and relationships:	**c) Seek the meaning from the details** Explain important words, phrases, and relationships:

d) Summarise the findings. What are the main ideas that come out of this initial study?

14.5 WORKSHEET FOR ENCOUNTERING TITUS 1:5-9 – STEPS 2 TO 4

STEP 2: SKELETON – outline the STRUCTURE of the text **a) Note all the bones in the structure.** What elements highlight the structure?
b) Decide on the 'big bones' and make an outline of the structure. What are the most important parts of the structure? Can you describe the main sections?
STEP 3: HEART – identify the MESSAGE of the text **a) State the theme of the passage.** What is the author's main point?
b) Explain the message of the passage. What is the author saying about his theme?
STEP 4: BRAIN – understand the PURPOSE of the text... **a) State the purpose of the passage.** Why is the author making his point?
b) Make connections for teaching today. What is the relevance of this for us?

14.6 PREACHING TITUS 1:5-9

In order to consider preaching Titus 1:5-9 we will, first, respond to the message at a more personal level, picking up on the discoveries we have already made. We will then use the table on the next page to capture some key ideas for a sermon or talk.

14.6.1 Responding to the message of Titus 1:5-9

Here are three simple exercises to do in response to God's word to us in the passage we have just encountered:

1. Describe how the message you discovered in the passage spoke to you personally: What did you learn or need to be reminded of?

2. Share how the purpose of the passage helped you to apply God's word to your life: What change will this passage make to your thinking and living?

3. State and explain the message you will share with others using your own words: What is the main thing you want people to understand?

14.6.2 Preaching the message of Titus 1:5-9

Use the table below to outline some of the key ideas for a sermon or talk:

STEP 4: BRAIN – State the PURPOSE of the sermon My sermon's purpose statement:
STEP 5: HEART – Form the MESSAGE of the sermon My sermon's theme and its message statement:
STEP 6: SKELETON – Create the STRUCTURE of the sermon My sermon's outline (with the main points, introduction and conclusion):
STEP 7: FLESH – Develop the DETAILS of the sermon My sermon's details (note here key words, explanations, illustrations and applications that will help you write notes or a full sermon):